



BEFORE

There is little evidence that early humans before Neanderthals buried their dead or believed in a higher power.

NEANDERTHAL BELIEF

Neanderthals **◀ 19** first buried their dead at least 60,000 years ago.

CONSCIOUS THOUGHT

Homo sapiens is unique in **thinking and planning ahead**, and in conceptualizing ideas. Such cognitive abilities first appeared around 50,000 years ago, and perhaps even earlier **◀ 21**.

A wealth of grave goods

Two 25,000-year-old hunter-gatherers buried in Sungir near Vladimir in Russia lie surrounded by spears, bracelets, brooches, and thousands of ivory beads.

The Spirit World

Ever since humans became conscious of their own frailty and mortality, they have sought the answers to the eternal mysteries of life. Theories about the purpose of our existence and questions about what happens after we die will always be a part of the human experience.

It is difficult to know what the beliefs of humans were before the advent of writing. However, from the material remains left to us, we can piece together some of the ideas of the particular culture that created them. The main ways in which we know about prehistoric religion today are from images painted on cave walls, and from objects found in graves (grave goods). Death is often

thought of as a link to another world, and the practices surrounding burial are always significant. The art of early humans found in caves and on bone carvings are indications of their beliefs outside of their everyday existence.

From about 40,000 years ago, the Cro-Magnons of western Europe developed a flamboyant artistic tradition that survives on cave walls

and on beautifully carved and engraved antler tools (see pp.20–21). The cave engravings and paintings depict a wide range of animals, some of them long extinct, such as the mammoth and woolly rhinoceros; others, like wild horses, European bison, and reindeer are more familiar today. The animals on the cave walls reflect a harsh late Ice Age environment where people survived

